

# Theories of Adult Learning

Jim Pham

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# Agenda

- Andragogy
- Other models for adult learning
- Summary

# Andragogy

- The art and science of helping adults learn.
- The focus is on the adult learner and the specific situation they are in.

# Andragogy: Model of Assumptions

1. **[Self-directing]** As a person matures, their self-concept moves from being dependent toward being self-directing.
2. **[Experience]** An adult accumulates a growing reservoir of experience, which is a rich resource for learning.
3. **[Readiness to learn]** An adult's readiness to learn is closely tied to the developmental tasks of their social role.
4. **[Problem-centered]** As people mature, they seek immediacy of knowledge to an application, so adults are more problem-centered than subject-centered.
5. **[Motivation]** Adults are motivated to learn by internal factors, not external ones.

# Models for Adult Learning

- Cross's CAL model (1981)
- McCluskey's Theory of Margin
- Knox's Proficiency Theory
- Jarvis's Learning Process

# CAL (Characteristics of Adults as Learners) Model

## **Personal Characteristics**

- >Physiological/Aging----->
- >Socialculture/Life phases----->
- >Physiological/Developmental stages----->

## **Situational Characteristics**

Part-time learning versus full-time learning  
Voluntary learning versus compulsory learning

*Source: Cross, 1981, p. 235*

# Problems with CAL Model

- Variables may be too broadly defined
- Focused on characteristics of adults
- Tells us little about how adults learn or if they learn differently than children do
- Personal characteristics could apply to children since they are on continua
- Situational characteristics do not distinguish adults from children
- Some adults are full-time, and some participate because of mandatory requirements
- Some pre-adults are part-time learners, and some learning is voluntary

# McCluskey's Theory of Margin

$$M = L/P$$

- M  $\Rightarrow$  margin left for learning
- Load  $\Rightarrow$  load of life
- Power  $\Rightarrow$  power of life

Outcome: The more margin one has, the greater the chance of dealing with sources of load. The less margin one has, the lower the chance of dealing with sources of load.



# Factors of Mcluskey's Theory of Margin

## **Load Factors:**

- External: normal life tasks - family (tasks of life such as family), work (career), community (socio-economic status)
- Internal: life expectancies developed by people – aspirations (self-concept), desires (goals), future expectations (personal expectations)

## **Power Factors:**

- External resources like family support, social abilities, and economic abilities
- Internally acquired or accumulated skills and experiences such as resilience, coping skills, and personality

# Knox's Proficiency Theory

- A model representation of the theory contains the following interactive components: (a) the general environment, (b) past and current characteristics, (c) performance, (d) aspiration, (e) self, (f) discrepancies, (g) specific environments, (h) learning activity, and (i) teacher's role.

*In this model, all components interact with each other.*

## Problems with Knox's Proficiency Theory

- This theory is not well known to adult educators.
- Emphasis on performance appears to limit application to learning that can be demonstrated by better performance
- How track interaction of the mix of learning, teaching, and motivation to explain learning?

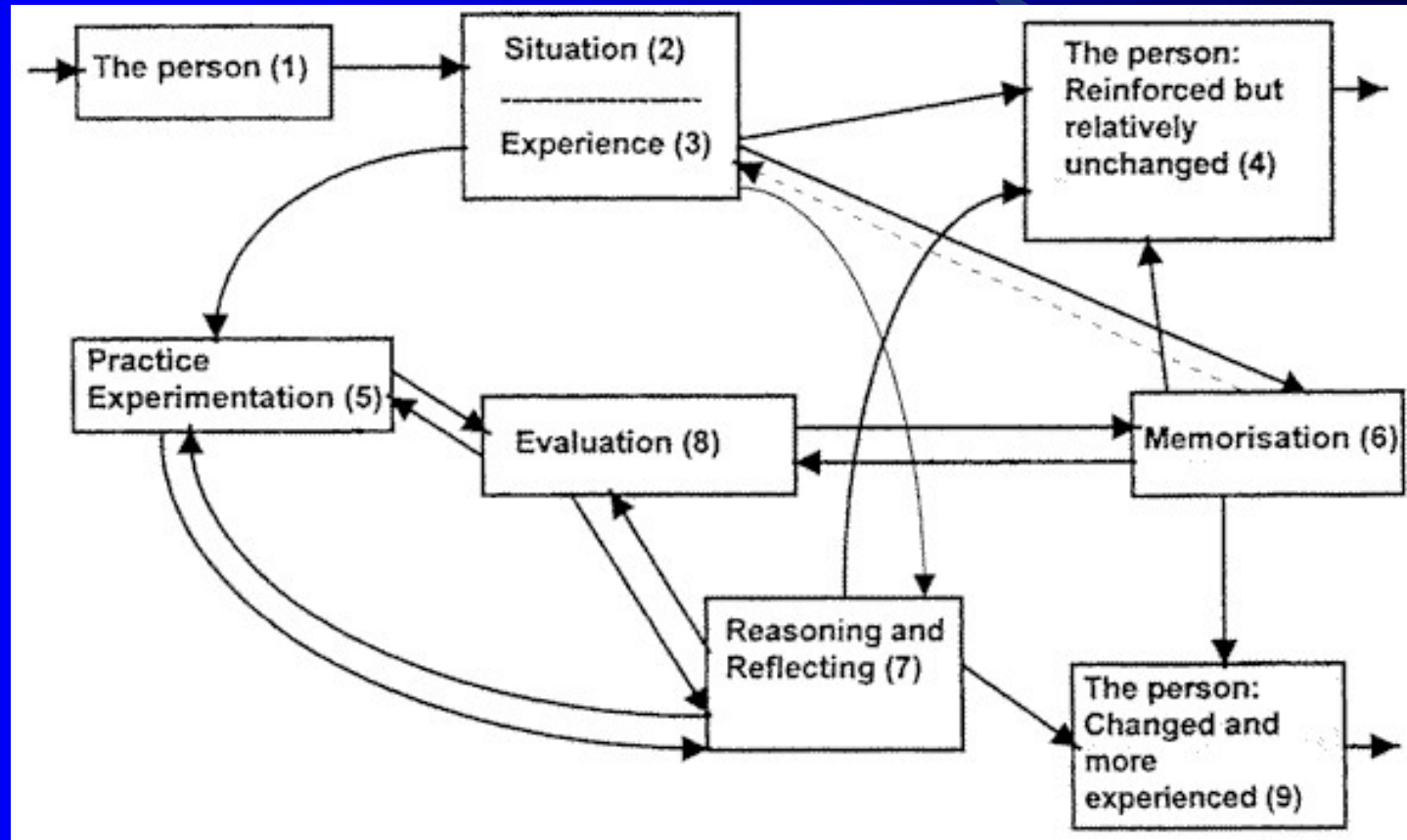
# Jarvis's Learning Process

- All learning begins with experience, but lots of experience is routine, so the key is that the learning process starts when an experience calls for a response.

# Jarvis's Learning Process - Strengths

- Deals with the learning process itself more than other models.
- Concentrates on explaining the responses to an experience
- These responses include many types of learning and their outcomes
- Situated in a social context
- Learning is interactive
- Constructed from research with adult learners
- Has been used in various settings

# Jarvis's Learning Process Model



*reproduced from Jarvis 1994*

# Summary

- Although the theories or models described in this presentation have not been fully developed and empirically tested, each is a good practice to understand adult learning.

# Where to Get More Information

- Merriam, S. B., and Caffarella, R. S. Learning in Adulthood. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 1991.
- <http://home.twcny.rr.com/hiemstra/ndacesm.html>
- <http://www-distance.syr.edu/margin.html>